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Love Conquers All

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Love Conquers All

Romans 8:28-39

Our youngest son was just a few months old when I, at age 32, started feeling horribly dizzy and began seeing double. The next evening, exhausted after a long day of doctor's appointments, I lay in an MRI machine, alone and afraid. Then I remembered Romans 8:28: "And we know that in all things God works for the good of those who love him, who have been called according to his purpose."

"I am going to be OK," I told myself. "God is going to work this out for good."

But things didn't go as I had planned. The next day, I was diagnosed with Multiple Sclerosis. No! We had four young children and were moving to another state in a few weeks where I had a perfect university job awaiting. No! This wasn't good! For two years I did everything the doctors told me to do, but the disease only progressed. I couldn't do my job. Some days I couldn't even take care of our kids. My sister and her family moved from out of state to help us. In weakness, depression and confusion, I struggled with God, "What are you doing? This isn't 'good'!"

But as I slowly came to realize, God's definition of good doesn't necessarily mean having a job you like or being healthy so you can get back to living your version of a "good" Christian life. In fact, after the experience at Edna's, as I grew to understand more of God's love for me, I began to see that God's definition of good is actually given in the verse following Romans 8:28. Romans 8:29 says, "For those God foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son, that he might be the firstborn among many brothers and sisters."

Now I understand! In every hurtful event and circumstance in our lives, God is working to make us like Jesus—to bring us into perfect union with Himself. God's definition of good—His loving plan—is to restore us to life on earth as He had designed in the beginning. We were created in the image of God—to be like Jesus. And God, in His great love for us, has made a way for us to be restored to His original intent.

In this passage, Paul makes it clear: God predestines, He calls, He justifies, and He glorifies. And when we are glorified, the nature of Christ—the love of God—characterizes our lives. In oneness with God, His loving nature becomes ours so that we are conformed to the image of His Son. Truly, "We are more than conquerors through him who loved us!"

Read Romans 8:28-39.

28And we know that in all things God works for the good of those who love him, who

have been called according to his purpose. 29For those God foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son, that he might be the firstborn among many brothers and sisters. 30And those he predestined, he also called; those he called, he also justified; those he justified, he also glorified.

31What, then, shall we say in response to these things? If God is for us, who can be against us? 32He who did not spare his own Son, but gave him up for us all—how will he not also, along with him, graciously give us all things? 33Who will bring any charge against those whom God has chosen? It is God who justifies. 34Who then is the one who condemns? No one. Christ Jesus who died—more than that, who was raised to life—is at the right hand of God and is also interceding for us. 35Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall trouble or hardship or persecution or famine or nakedness or danger or sword? 36 As it is written: ‘For your sake we face death all day long; we are considered as sheep to be slaughtered.’ 37No, in all these things we are more than conquerors through him who loved us. 38For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor demons, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, 39neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord.

Questions

1. Consider your own life experiences as they relate to Romans 8:28. If possible, give an example of something good that has come out of something “bad” in your life.
2. What do verses 29–30 tell us about God’s purpose for us?
3. What do these verses tell us about how God planned and promised for us to become conformed to the image of His Son?
4. What part do we play in being conformed to the image of Jesus Christ?
5. Paul says in verse 30, “he also glorified.” God has actually made a way for us to be glorified. Imagine and describe what a glorified person might look/be like.
6. In verses 31–34, Paul asks five questions. Choose one of the questions and answer it.
7. How does God define a conqueror? How can a “sheep to be slaughtered” (verse 36) be more than a conqueror (verse 37)?
8. In what ways does Jesus’ love for you make you more than a conqueror?

9. What, if anything, is keeping you personally from living like a conqueror—from living glorified?
0. In verse 35, Paul asks, “Who shall separate us from the love of Christ?” In verses 38–39 he answers this question. Describe his answer in your own words.
 1. What are you afraid might separate you from God and His love? How does this passage address those fears?
 2. Recall and describe a time when you were especially aware of God’s loving presence. What impact did that time have on you?

Reflection

Sit quietly for a moment. Be aware of God’s love surrounding you like air. Nothing can dampen or lessen that love. Nothing can separate you from it. Keep your eyes on Him. Breathe in His love and all the promises that come with it.

Rest in knowing you are predestined. God called you. Through the blood of Jesus you are justified. In loving relationship with God you are glorified. God in His love has provided these things for you.

Believe. Only believe. In God’s vast goodness, you are not afraid. You are bold and courageous. You are more than a conqueror through Him who loves you. You are shining with God’s goodness—sharing His glory—in the darkness of this world. Go forth radiating the love of Jesus to all you encounter.

Onward, Forever Loved!